

The Morning Briefing

 Marcus Johnson's Sunday Edition · U.S. Politics & Law · Israel & the Middle East · World · Markets · Long Reads

Iran War Widens as U.S. Strikes Near Hormuz, Tehran Hits Back Across the Gulf

A week of escalation turns the Strait of Hormuz into the hinge of the global economy — and pulls Israel's stated war aims further past Washington's.

The defining story of the week was not a single event but an escalation curve. On Tuesday, President Trump announced "large and powerful" American strikes on Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps targets near the Strait of Hormuz, framed as retaliation for an Iranian attempt to mine the strait and for attacks on U.S. personnel in the region. By Wednesday, Iran had hit back at American bases across Jordan, Bahrain and Kuwait; a U.S. strike that reportedly hit a home hosting a wedding, killing five, further inflamed the exchange. By Friday and Saturday, Iran's navy said it had targeted oil tankers transiting the strait, including a vessel near Kharg Island, and threatened "more severe attacks" on the U.S. Navy. Trump has said he does not expect the latest round to last much longer; Tehran's posture suggests otherwise.

This is not a new war — the conflict traces to February 28 — but this week marks a sharp re-escalation after a shaky ceasefire and a since-collapsed June memorandum of understanding. The strategic picture has not improved for Washington: shipping through Hormuz, a corridor for roughly a fifth of the world's seaborne oil, has collapsed to a fraction of pre-war traffic, and Brent crude is running about 16 percent above pre-war levels. Foreign Affairs contributor Robert Pape's argument that horizontal escalation favors the weaker party looks more prescient by the week (see Long Reads).

U.S. POLITICS

Government Funded Through December, But the House Goes Quiet

Congress avoided a fall shutdown this week when the House passed, 370-48, a Senate-approved continuing resolution funding the government through December 11; Trump signed it September 1. That single achievement appears to be most of what House Republican leadership plans to do before Election Day — GOP leaders have canceled the final two scheduled September session weeks, leaving the chamber with only a handful of voting days before members go home to campaign. What floor time remains is expected to go toward messaging bills designed to put moderate Democrats on record on hot-button issues rather than toward substantive legislating.

Defense One · [defenseone.com/policy/2026/09/shutdown-threat-lifted-house-passes-stopgap-spending-bill](https://www.defenseone.com/policy/2026/09/shutdown-threat-lifted-house-passes-stopgap-spending-bill)

Bloomberg Government · [news.bgov.com/bloomberg-government-news/house-cancels-two-session-weeks-in-september-ahead-of-midterms](https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-09-03/bloomberg-government-news-house-cancels-two-session-weeks-in-september-ahead-of-midterms)

The Mail Ballot Fight Goes to the Shadow Docket

The most consequential live fight in Washington right now may be procedural: the Justice Department this week asked the Supreme Court to let a new U.S. Postal Service rule take effect for the midterms, requiring local election officials to use federally approved ballot envelopes and to upload voters' ballot-tracking data to a USPS portal. U.S. District Judge Indira Talwani had blocked the rule days

earlier, finding that the administration's timeline — imposed less than seventy days before the election — risked disenfranchising mail voters and usurped a state power that would ordinarily require congressional authorization. The emergency application is now pending at the Court, with ballots already going out in some states. However the justices rule, the case is a preview of how much of this midterm cycle's ground rules will be set on the emergency docket rather than through ordinary litigation.

NBC News · [nbcnews.com/politics/trump-administration/justice-department-usps-supreme-court-action-mail-ballots-elections-rcna595924](https://www.nbcnews.com/politics/trump-administration/justice-department-usps-supreme-court-action-mail-ballots-elections-rcna595924)

NPR · [npr.org/2026/09/03/nx-s1-5955614/trump-mail-in-voting-ruling-court-usps](https://www.npr.org/2026/09/03/nx-s1-5955614/trump-mail-in-voting-ruling-court-usps)

Missouri Voters Get the Final Word on Their Map

The Missouri Supreme Court unanimously blocked the state's Trump-requested congressional gerrymander from being used in November and ordered a referendum on the map for the same ballot, ruling that the state constitution's referendum power over "any act" of the legislature extends to redistricting. Because the petition had enough signatures, the 2025 map is suspended and the 2022 lines will govern this cycle unless voters affirmatively approve the new one. It is one data point in a much larger redistricting scramble this cycle that, per one national tally, currently leaves Republicans positioned

to net as many as sixteen or seventeen House seats against a Democratic ceiling of about six — a reminder that the House majority is increasingly being decided in state courthouses and ballot initiatives as much as at the ballot box in November.

ANALYSIS

The mail-ballot rule and the Missouri ruling are the same story from two directions: both are fights over who controls the machinery of the 2026 election, decided under time pressure by courts rather than legislatures.

When execution timelines get this tight, procedure becomes substance — a state court's reading of "any act" or a single justice's vote on standing carries as much weight as anything Congress does. Watch for more of this compressed, court-driven rule-setting as Election Day nears.

CNN · cnn.com/2026/09/03/politics/missouri-supreme-court-blocks-trump-backed-map-midterms

NBC News · nbcnews.com/politics/2026-election/house-redistricting-gop-democrats-2026-midterm-elections-rcna348110

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

Roberts Breaks With the Right on the White House Ballroom Case

In a genuinely unusual alignment, Chief Justice Roberts joined Justices Sotomayor, Kagan and Jackson in dissent on August 31 as the Court's other five conservatives stayed a lower-court injunction that had halted construction of the White House ballroom project. The majority did not rule on whether the demolition of the East Wing and construction of the new ballroom and below-ground facility was lawful; it held only that the National Trust for Historic Preservation likely lacks Article III standing, because an "aesthetic injury" from viewing an altered building does not meet the bar for a concrete, particularized harm. Roberts's dissent argued the analogy to environmental standing cases — where a person's regular, personal connection to a specific place can support standing — should have applied here, and that the Trust was likely correct on the merits that only Congress can authorize this scale of change to the White House. The stay lets construction continue indefinitely while the underlying case proceeds.

ANALYSIS

A Chief Justice this institutionally cautious does not join a four-justice dissent lightly. Roberts's vote suggests he sees the majority's standing theory as doing real work to avoid

a separation-of-powers merits question the administration would rather not litigate — not a neutral procedural call. Standing doctrine is being used here as it has been used elsewhere this year: as a release valve on the emergency docket that lets the Court avoid ruling on executive power while still delivering the executive branch a practical win.

SCOTUSblog · scotusblog.com/2026/08/supreme-court-allows-construction-on-white-house-ballroom-to-continue

Slate · slate.com/news-and-politics/2026/09/supreme-court-trump-ballroom-john-roberts-technicality.html

Missouri's Referendum Ruling, Again, as a Judiciary Story

Beyond its midterm-math implications (see U.S. Politics), the Missouri Supreme Court's ruling is itself a notable piece of state constitutional interpretation: a unanimous court read a general referendum clause to reach a specific, high-stakes act of the legislature, over Republican objections that redistricting was implicitly exempted. Expect this reasoning to be cited in other states' referendum fights over legislatively drawn maps.

Missouri Independent · missouriindependent.com/2026/09/03/missouri-supreme-court-blocks-gerrymandered-congressional-map-orders-referendum-vote

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Netanyahu Names Regime Change as the "Central Mission" — a Goal Bigger Than Washington's

Prime Minister Netanyahu told the country in a Rosh Hashanah address this week that toppling the Iranian regime is Israel's central war aim and that the goal is within reach. That is a significantly more expansive objective than anything the Trump administration has publicly committed to, and it matters: Israel is effectively defining the war's endpoint for a conflict in which American forces are also directly engaged and American shipping lanes are directly at risk. Separately, Israeli officials briefed Hebrew-language media this week that they had not observed Iran's ceasefire commitments eroding — a claim worth treating as positioning for a

domestic and international audience rather than as verified assessment, given it comes from anonymous officials rather than an on-record source.

ANALYSIS

Regime change is Israel's stated goal, not America's, and the gap matters. A U.S. president who has said publicly he doesn't expect this round to last much longer is not obviously aligned with an Israeli government that has just told its own public the war continues until Tehran falls. If the objectives diverge further, Washington may find itself committed to a Gulf conflict on a timeline set in Jerusalem rather than in the White House — the classic risk of a junior partner's stated aims outrunning the patron's.

Critical Threats (AEI) · criticalthreats.org/analysis/iran-update-september-3-2026

The Times of Israel · timesofisrael.com/liveblog-september-05-2026

Ben Gvir's Gaza "Emigration" Plan — and Trump's Fingerprints on It

National Security Minister Itamar Ben Gvir unveiled "Disengagement 710" this week, a plan targeting the departure of 250,000 Gazans in its first year and up to 1.86 million within seven, dressed as "voluntary emigration" with a Turkey/Ethiopia/Congo relocation menu and a temporary support package. UN experts have already warned that engineering a population's departure under conditions of war and blockade cannot meaningfully be called voluntary and would violate international law; no country has agreed to take anyone. Defense Minister Katz says a version of this idea is "frozen" at Trump's direction — but Trump himself floated Gaza depopulation as a policy option earlier this year, which is precisely what gave Ben Gvir's plan the political cover to be unveiled at all. This is an explicitly pre-election maneuver by Israel's far right, not primarily a security policy.

ANALYSIS

Cui bono: Ben Gvir gains a campaign issue that consolidates the far-right flank ahead of elections; Netanyahu gets to let his coalition partner take the international heat while Israel's own hands stay technically clean; and Washington gets the deniability of calling it "frozen" while the idea keeps circulating with the American president's own past rhetoric as its intellectual cover. Nobody in this chain has to own the plan outright, which is exactly how it survives.

The Jerusalem Post · jpost.com/israel-election-2026/article-907523

The Times of Israel · timesofisrael.com/ben-gvir-unveils-voluntary-emigration-plan-to-remove-most-palestinians-from-gaza

Netanyahu Publicly Defies the Kushner Peace Track

Jared Kushner held a rare, more-than-two-hour meeting with Hamas leader Khalil al-Hayya in Egypt this week — alongside Egyptian, Qatari and Turkish mediators — trying to revive the 15-point U.S.-backed road map for

Hamas disarmament and an Israeli withdrawal. He then met Netanyahu in Jerusalem, who rejected the plan outright, an unusually public break from Israel's closest ally. Hamas, for its part, is calling on mediators and the U.S.-created Board of Peace to compel Israeli compliance with a road map Israel has never fully accepted.

PBS NewsHour · pbs.org/newshour/world/kushner-has-rare-meeting-with-hamas-leader-on-gaza-road-map-a-meeting-with-netanyahu-is-next

Al Jazeera · aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/17/why-kushner-met-hamas-leaders-and-what-it-means-for-trumps-gaza-roadmap

West Bank: Annexation Measures Escalate Under Cover of the Wider War

With international attention absorbed by Iran and Gaza, settlement activity in the West Bank continued to accelerate this week. Amnesty International documented Israeli military land-seizure orders in Area A near Jenin — nominally under Palestinian civil control since the Oslo Accords — issued openly for settler benefit rather than under a security rationale, which watchdog group Peace Now says is a first since Oslo. Settler violence continued in parallel: an elderly Palestinian woman and an NBC news crew were attacked in Jalud in late August, and a mosque was set on fire near Nablus on September 1. Finance Minister Smotrich has described his broader program as aiming to bring a million settlers into the West Bank.

ANALYSIS

None of this is happening in spite of the Iran war and Gaza diplomacy — it is happening because of the bandwidth those crises absorb. A wartime government facing minimal international scrutiny on its highest-profile files has more room, not less, to move on its quietest one. That is worth remembering the next time West Bank annexation gets described as a separate track from the "real" war.

Amnesty International · amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2026/09/israel-opt-israel-steps-up-annexation-measures-with-unlawful-land-seizure-orders-in-the-occupied-west-bank

FMEP · fmep.org/resource/settlement-annexation-report-september-4-2026

WORLD

Moscow, Beijing Frame the Iran War as American Overreach

Russia and China have both condemned the U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran as unprovoked aggression against a sovereign state, and both are alleged to be providing Tehran material and intelligence support. That positioning is not costless for Washington: analysts note Russia has used the Hormuz-driven oil price spike to win back India as a crude customer and refresh war financing for Ukraine, while China is positioned to help rebuild Iran's military in exchange for future energy access. European leaders — Starmer, Macron, Merz — have called for a negotiated settlement rather than backing the strikes outright, while Australia and Canada offered open support; most of the Global South has stayed pointedly non-aligned. Gulf states including Saudi Arabia and Egypt

have criticized Iran's attacks on shipping, a reminder that regional Sunni Arab states' interests do not track neatly with either Washington's or Tehran's.

ANALYSIS

A war Washington may see as a limited campaign against Iranian capability is, for Moscow, a free subsidy on its own war economy. That's the great-power-competition dimension that tends to get lost in day-to-day coverage of strikes and counter-strikes: every week Hormuz stays disrupted is a week the Kremlin's oil math gets easier.

Al Jazeera · aljazeera.com/news/2026/3/4/russia-china-raise-diplomatic-voices-against-us-israeli-attacks-on-iran

CNBC · cnbc.com/2026/03/02/iran-china-russia-strikes-assistance-alliance-weapons-missiles-geopolitics-oil-prices-ukraine.html

Witkoff and Kushner Take the Ukraine File to Moscow

The same two envoys carrying the Gaza portfolio arrived in Moscow this weekend for a renewed push to end the Russia-Ukraine war, after President Zelensky proposed a temporary mutual ceasefire on air strikes to create space for talks. Moscow had not publicly responded to the offer as of this weekend, and both sides escalated aerial attacks even as the envoys traveled. The U.S. has separately paused direct military aid to Ukraine, a fact that will shape how much leverage Witkoff and Kushner actually carry into the Kremlin meetings.

ANALYSIS

Two envoys running Gaza, Ukraine, and by extension a piece of the broader Russia relationship at the same moment the U.S. is also engaged in an active shooting war with Iran is a real bandwidth constraint, not just a

scheduling curiosity. Diplomatic capital is finite; a White House this stretched has less room to extract concessions on any single file.

NPR / Houston Public Media · houstonpublicmedia.org/npr/2026/09/05/nx-s1-5959114/u-s-envoys-in-moscow-in-new-push-for-peace-between-russia-and-ukraine

Taiwan Strait Tensions Simmer Beneath the Iran Headlines

Taiwan's defense ministry warned this week that China's PLA is intensifying blockade preparations, and Taiwan responded with its own blockade-simulation drills. The temperature is lower than the acute crisis of late 2025, helped by several direct U.S.-China leader engagements this year, but the underlying trajectory — Beijing methodically normalizing coercive pressure short of open conflict — continues unchanged and unresolved.

AEI China & Taiwan Update · aei.org/commentary/china-taiwan-update-september-4-2026

FINANCIALS

Equities drifted lower into the weekend — Apple, Lockheed, BlackRock and Exxon all closed Friday in the red — even though the earnings backdrop remains strong across the board (all four beat both revenue and EPS estimates last quarter). The real story of the week was in oil and gold, not stocks: Brent has stayed elevated on the Hormuz disruption even as Friday brought some profit-taking in gold off its recent highs. August's nonfarm payrolls report, released Friday, beat expectations with unemployment holding at 4.1 percent, keeping the Federal Reserve on a likely path to another quarter-point rate cut at its meeting this coming week. None of the four equities' Friday declines look tied to company-specific news; they read as a market broadly pricing in geopolitical risk premium heading into a week that will bring both a Fed decision and whatever comes next out of the Persian Gulf.

AAPL (Apple Inc.) — \$319.97, -2.51% today. *Upper half of 52-week range.* 52-wk range position: 79%. Analyst avg. target upside: +5.49%.

LMT (Lockheed Martin Corp.) — \$525.28, -1.44% today. *Lower half of 52-week range; Street sees meaningful upside to target.* 52-wk range position: 35%. Analyst avg. target upside: +18.53%.

BLK (BlackRock Inc.) — \$1,122.29, -0.34% today. *Upper half of 52-week range; Street sees meaningful upside to target.* 52-wk range position: 68%. Analyst avg. target upside: +17.69%.

XOM (Exxon Mobil Corp.) — \$159.47, -1.69% today. *Upper half of 52-week range.* 52-wk range position: 75%. Analyst avg. target upside: +5.64%.

BTC-USD (Bitcoin) — \$79,900, +0.09% today. *Consolidating.*

XAU (Gold (spot)) — \$4,432.56, -0.92% today. *Safe-haven bid fading.*

Market Predictions & Moves

No dominant cross-asset signal today — moves look idiosyncratic, not macro-driven.

Informational market read compiled 2026-09-06, not personalized financial advice.

Google Finance · google.com/finance (AAPL:NASDAQ, LMT:NYSE, XOM:NYSE, BTC-USD)

StockAnalysis.com · stockanalysis.com/stocks/blk

Bloomberg · bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-09-04/fed-rate-decision-still-hangs-on-inflation-after-jobs-report

TradingEconomics / market wires · tradingeconomics.com/commodity/gold

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Geopolitics — "Why Escalation Favors Iran," Robert A. Pape (Foreign Affairs)

University of Chicago security scholar Robert Pape argues that Iran's strategy of horizontal escalation — widening the war into shipping lanes, energy markets and regional proxies rather than matching U.S. and Israeli firepower directly — follows a historical pattern in which a weaker power outlasts a stronger one by raising the war's costs

and duration rather than its intensity. He draws the comparison to Vietnam and Serbia, where American airpower dominance failed to translate into strategic victory once the adversary widened the conflict's scope. Given this week's tanker attacks and threats of further Hormuz disruption, Pape's argument reads less like commentary and more like a live diagnosis.

Full text: foreignaffairs.com/iran/why-escalation-favors-iran

Constitutional Law — "The Supreme Court Is Letting Trump Get His White House Ballroom on a Technicality" (Slate)

This analysis of the August 31 ballroom ruling (see Judiciary) walks through how the Court's conservative majority used Article III standing doctrine to sidestep a separation-of-powers question — whether the executive

can unilaterally alter the White House at this scale without congressional authorization — while still delivering a practical win to the administration. It's a useful companion to Roberts's dissent for understanding how standing doctrine has become a load-bearing tool on the emergency docket more broadly this term.

Full text: slate.com/news-and-politics/2026/09/supreme-court-trump-ballroom-john-roberts-technicality.html

The Morning Briefing — compiled Sunday, September 6, 2026 — informational digest, not personalized advice of any kind.